A Worksheet on Comparative Syntax

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Consider the following questions.

1. Examine observations (1)–(9) on Japanese syntax on pages 4–6.

   (a) In some of these observations, two forms of the same nominal expression are possible while preserving the grammatical functions and thematic roles of the expressions involved. Identify the morphological alternation.

   (b) Under what syntactic conditions is this alternation available, and under what conditions is it not? State empirical generalizations that capture its distribution.

   (c) Is there any correlation between this alternation and displacement? If so, identify the relevant type of displacement and the grammatical relation of the displaced element, and state the correlation.

2. Examine observations (10)–(21) on French syntax on pages 6–9.

   (a) In some of these observations, two different word orders are possible while preserving the grammatical functions and thematic roles of the expressions involved. Identify the word-order alternation.

   (b) Under what syntactic conditions is this alternation available, and under what conditions is it not? State empirical generalizations that capture its distribution.

   (c) Is there any correlation between this alternation and displacement? If so, identify the relevant type of displacement and the grammatical relation of the displaced element, and state the correlation.

3. Phrasal displacement is commonly classified into two broad types according to its syntactic behavior. Let us use the term *wh-displacement* for the type to which displacement of overt interrogative and relative expressions in English belongs.

   (a) What are the observational criteria for identifying syntactic displacement?

   (b) What syntactic properties distinguish *wh*-displacement from the other type of displacement?

(c) Give examples of *wh*-displacement other than the displacement of overt interrogative and relative expressions.

(d) Compare the empirical generalizations stated in Questions 1 and 2. What similarities do you find between the two alternations?

(e) What syntactic differences do you find between the two alternations?

The questions continue on the next page.

Tips: Some Linguistic Background

The following are some basic syntactic properties of Japanese and French that will be useful for understanding the observations.

1. **Basic word order.** Japanese is predominantly head-final, whereas French is predominantly head-initial. For example, the basic word order is SOV in Japanese and SVO in French.

2. **Scrambling.** Japanese allows scrambling of nominal expressions, so their surface order may differ from the basic word order.

3. **Articles.** Unlike French, Japanese has no articles. Japanese noun phrases can receive either definite or indefinite interpretations, depending on the context.

4. **Relative clauses.** Japanese relative clauses precede the nouns they modify, whereas French relative clauses follow the nouns they modify. Japanese typically employs the *gapping strategy*, in which the relativized element is not overtly expressed within the relative clause. French can employ the *relative pronoun strategy*, as in English, in which an overt relative pronoun, such as *lequel*, appears in the relative clause.

5. **Japanese particles.** Japanese has particles that occur after nominal expressions, including *-ga*, *-no*, *-o*, and *-ni*. In the examples below, these particles are glossed by their phonological forms rather than by grammatical functions or abstract Case categories.

6. **Subjunctive and indicative clauses.** French distinguishes indicative and subjunctive moods in finite clauses. The choice of mood depends in part on the clause's syntactic environment, including the selecting predicate.

4. Assume the following, based on the early Minimalist framework discussed in Watanabe (1996):

   - Abstract Case must be checked by the end of a derivation through a Spec–head relation with Agr. Case checking takes place as soon as the relevant Spec–head relation is established.
   - Phrasal movement to an A-position is blocked if an intervening A-position and the landing site are not equidistant from the original position.
   - Head movement cannot skip an intervening head.
   - Phrasal movement can apply in two successive rounds, one before the PF–LF split (Spell-Out) and another after it. In each round, movement applies cyclically, proceeding from structurally lower positions to structurally higher positions.
   - No new Spec–head relation with T can be established after the PF–LF split.
   - All phrasal movement involves substitution into a specifier position rather than adjunction to a phrase.

   If necessary, you may assume that Spec-TP is not an $\overline{\text{A}}$-position.

   (a) Show that, in the derivation of an active transitive clause, checking the accusative Case of the object before the PF–LF split requires the main verb to undergo head movement to T in the same clause before the PF–LF split.

   (b) Show that, in the derivation of an active transitive clause, for the accusative Case of the object to be checked while the subject remains within VP, a new Spec–head relation between the subject and T must be established after the accusative Case of the object has been checked.

   (c) Suppose, in addition, that no Spec–head relation with T can be established even before the PF–LF split. Under this assumption, can the accusative Case of the object of a verb in an active transitive clause be checked before the PF–LF split? Furthermore, consider active transitive expletive constructions in particular. Can the object bear accusative Case in such constructions?

   Now assume that, in both French and Japanese, no Spec–head relation with T can be established either before or after the PF–LF split, and that the direct object of a verb in an active transitive clause bears accusative Case.

   (g) Consider the French word-order alternation examined in Question 2. Assume that the postverbal subject remains within VP at the PF–LF split and that its nominative Case is subsequently checked.
   Show that, for this alternation to be available in an active transitive clause, the direct object must undergo *wh*-movement.

   (h) Consider the Japanese morphological alternation examined in Question 1. Assume that the subject marked with *-no* remains within VP at the PF–LF split and that its nominative Case is subsequently checked.
   Show that, for this alternation to be available in an active transitive clause whose direct object is marked with *-o*, the direct object must undergo *wh*-movement.

Observations

The following examples are based on Watanabe (1996).* Some baseline sentences and comparison forms have been added for the purposes of this exercise. I thank Lena Abirou, Amelia Monk and Victor Chamot for their judgments and comments on the French examples in (11), (12), and (18).

I. Japanese

(1) Apply relativization of the direct object to (a), and compare (b) and (c), which differ in the morphological marking on the subject of the relative clause.
(cf. Watanabe 1996: (1))

a. Kinoo John-ga hon-o katta.
yesterday John-GA book-O bought
'John bought a book yesterday.'

b. [Kinoo John-ga katta] hon
yesterday John-GA bought book
'the book that John bought yesterday'

c. [Kinoo John-no katta] hon
yesterday John-NO bought book
'the book that John bought yesterday'

(2) Embed (a) as a *koto*-clause serving as the complement of *sir-* 'know', as in *John-wa . . . -o siranakatta* 'John did not know . . . ', and compare the morphological marking on the subject of the embedded clause in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (2))

a. Kinoo Mary-ga kita.
yesterday Mary-GA came
'Mary came yesterday.'

b. John-wa [kinoo Mary-ga kita] koto-o siranakatta.
John-WA yesterday Mary-GA came KOTO-O did.not.know
'John did not know that Mary came yesterday.'

c. John-wa [kinoo Mary-no kita] koto-o siranakatta.
John-WA yesterday Mary-NO came KOTO-O did.not.know
'John did not know that Mary came yesterday.'

(3) Form a comparative construction based on (a), and compare the morphological marking on the subject in the comparative clause in (b) and (c).
(cf. Watanabe 1996: (45a))

a. Mary-ga takusanno hon-o yonda.
Mary-GA many book-O read
'Mary read many books.'

b. John-wa [Mary-ga yonda yori] takusanno hon-o yonda.
John-WA Mary-GA read than many book-O read
'John read more books than Mary did.'

*Watanabe, Akira (1996) Nominative-genitive conversion and agreement in Japanese: A cross-linguistic perspective. *Journal of East Asian Linguistics* 5: 373–410.

c. John-wa [Mary-no yonda yori] takusanno hon-o yonda.
John-WA Mary-NO read than many book-O read
'John read more books than Mary did.'

(4) Embed (a) as a *to*-clause under *John-wa . . . omotta* 'John thought . . . ', and compare the morphological marking on the subject of the embedded clause in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (3a))

a. Kinoo Mary-ga kita.
yesterday Mary-GA came
'Mary came yesterday.'

b. John-wa [kinoo Mary-ga kita to] omotta.
John-WA yesterday Mary-GA came TO thought
'John thought that Mary came yesterday.'

c. * John-wa [kinoo Mary-no kita to] omotta.
John-WA yesterday Mary-NO came TO thought
'John thought that Mary came yesterday.'

(5) Compare the morphological marking on the subject in the independent declarative sentences in (a) and (b). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (3b))

a. Kinoo Mary-ga kita.
yesterday Mary-GA came
'Mary came yesterday.'

b. * Kinoo Mary-no kita.
yesterday Mary-NO came
'Mary came yesterday.'

(6) Apply relativization of the direct object to (a), and compare the morphological marking on the subject of the relative clause in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (8), (56b))

a. John-ga Mary-ni hon-o kasita.
John-GA Mary-NI book-O lent
'John lent a book to Mary.'

b. [Mary-ni John-ga kasita] hon
Mary-NI John-GA lent book
'the book that John lent to Mary'

c. [Mary-ni John-no kasita] hon
Mary-NI John-NO lent book
'the book that John lent to Mary'

(7) Apply relativization of the indirect object to (a), and compare the morphological marking on the subject of the relative clause in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (6b))

a. John-ga Mary-ni hon-o kasita.
John-GA Mary-NI book-O lent
'John lent a book to Mary.'

b. [John-ga hon-o kasita] hito
John-GA book-O lent person
'the person to whom John lent a book'

c. * [John-no hon-o kasita] hito
John-NO book-O lent person
'the person to whom John lent a book'

(8) Apply relativization of the subject to (a), and compare the morphological marking on the remaining object in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (9))

a. Dareka-ga hon-o katta.
someone-GA book-O bought
'Someone bought a book.'

b. [Hon-o katta] hito
book-O bought person
'the person who bought a book'

c. * [Hon-no katta] hito
book-NO bought person
'the person who bought a book'

(9) Apply relativization to the direct object of the embedded clause in (a), and compare the morphological marking on the subjects of the matrix and embedded clauses in (b)–(d). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (39))

a. Mary-ga [John-ga hon-o katta to] omotte iru.
Mary-GA John-GA book-O bought TO thinking is
'Mary thinks that John bought a book.'

b. [Mary-ga [John-ga katta to] omotte iru] hon
Mary-GA John-GA bought TO thinking is book
'the book that Mary thinks John bought'

c. * [Mary-ga [John-no katta to] omotte iru] hon
Mary-GA John-NO bought TO thinking is book
'the book that Mary thinks John bought'

d. [Mary-no [John-ga katta to] omotte iru] hon
Mary-NO John-GA bought TO thinking is book
'the book that Mary thinks John bought'

II. French

(10) Apply relativization of the complement of *avec* to (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verbal complex in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (15))

a. Marie est sortie avec un homme.
Marie is gone.out with a man
'Marie went out with a man.'

b. l'homme avec lequel Marie est sortie
the.man with whom Marie is gone.out
'the man whom Marie went out with'

c. l'homme avec lequel est sortie Marie
the.man with whom is gone.out Marie
'the man whom Marie went out with'

(11) Form a comparative construction based on (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verb in the comparative clause in (b) and (c).

a. Paul a beaucoup de livres aujourd'hui.
Paul has many books today
'Paul has many books today.'

b. Pierre a plus de livres que Paul n'en a aujourd'hui.
Pierre has more of books than Paul NE.EN has today
'Pierre has more books than Paul does today.'

c. Pierre a plus de livres que n'en a Paul aujourd'hui.
Pierre has more of books than NE.EN has Paul today
'Pierre has more books than Paul does today.'

(12) Form a comparative construction based on (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verb in the comparative clause in (b) and (c).

a. Jeanne était triste hier.
Jeanne was sad yesterday
'Jeanne was sad yesterday.'

b. Elle est aussi triste que Jeanne l'était hier.
she is as sad as Jeanne it.was yesterday
'She is as sad as Jeanne was yesterday.'

c. Elle est aussi triste que l'était Jeanne hier.
she is as sad as it.was Jeanne yesterday
'She is as sad as Jeanne was yesterday.'

(13) Apply embedded *wh*-question formation to the temporal adjunct in (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verb in (b) and (c).
(cf. Watanabe 1996: (14b, b'))

a. Ton ami partira à un certain moment.
your friend will.leave at a certain moment
'Your friend will leave at a certain time.'

b. Je me demande quand ton ami partira.
I myself ask when your friend will.leave
'I wonder when your friend will leave.'

c. Je me demande quand partira ton ami.
I myself ask when will.leave your friend
'I wonder when your friend will leave.'

(14) Embed (a) as a subjunctive complement of *vouloir* 'want', and compare the relative order of the subject and the verb in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (14c, c'))

a. Paul part.
Paul leaves
'Paul leaves.'

b. Je veux que Paul parte.
I want that Paul leave.SUBJ
'I want Paul to leave.'

c. Je veux que parte Paul.
I want that leave.SUBJ Paul
'I want Paul to leave.'

(15) Embed (a) as an indicative complement of *dire* 'say', and compare the relative order of the subject and the verb in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (16a))

a. Son ami partira.
her friend will.leave
'Her friend will leave.'

b. Elle dit que son ami partira.
she says that her friend will.leave
'She says that her friend will leave.'

c. * Elle dit que partira son ami.
she says that will.leave her friend
'She says that her friend will leave.'

(16) Compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verb in the independent declarative sentences in (a) and (b). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (16b))

a. Ton ami partira.
your friend will.leave
'Your friend will leave.'

b. * Partira ton ami.
will.leave your friend
'Your friend will leave.'

(17) Apply relativization of the direct object to (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verbal complex in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (56a))

a. Lise a donné des livres à Jeanne hier.
Lise has given some books to Jeanne yesterday
'Lise gave some books to Jeanne yesterday.'

b. les livres que Lise a donnés à Jeanne hier
the books that Lise has given to Jeanne yesterday
'the books that Lise gave to Jeanne yesterday'

c. les livres qu'a donnés Lise à Jeanne hier
the books that.has given Lise to Jeanne yesterday
'the books that Lise gave to Jeanne yesterday'

(18) Apply relativization of the indirect object to (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the finite verbal complex in (b)–(d).

a. Lise a donné les livres à une personne hier.
Lise has given the books to a person yesterday
'Lise gave the books to a person yesterday.'

b. la personne à qui Lise a donné les livres hier
the person to whom Lise has given the books yesterday
'the person to whom Lise gave the books yesterday'

c. * la personne à qui a donné les livres Lise hier
the person to whom has given the books Lise yesterday
'the person to whom Lise gave the books yesterday'

d. * la personne à qui a donné Lise les livres hier
the person to whom has given Lise the books yesterday
'the person to whom Lise gave the books yesterday'

(19) Apply embedded *wh*-question formation to the temporal adjunct in (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the verb in (b)–(d). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (17))

a. Marie mangera sa pomme à un certain moment.
Marie will.eat her apple at a certain moment
'Marie will eat her apple at a certain time.'

b. Je me demande quand Marie mangera sa pomme.
I myself ask when Marie will.eat her apple
'I wonder when Marie will eat her apple.'

c. * Je me demande quand mangera Marie sa pomme.
I myself ask when will.eat Marie her apple
'I wonder when Marie will eat her apple.'

d. * Je me demande quand mangera sa pomme Marie.
I myself ask when will.eat her apple Marie
'I wonder when Marie will eat her apple.'

(20) Apply embedded *wh*-question formation to the direct object in (a), and compare the relative order of the subject and the verb in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (18))

a. Pierre préfère un livre.
Pierre prefers a book
'Pierre prefers a book.'

b. Je me demande quel livre Pierre préfère.
I myself ask which book Pierre prefers
'I wonder which book Pierre prefers.'

c. Je me demande quel livre préfère Pierre.
I myself ask which book prefers Pierre
'I wonder which book Pierre prefers.'

(21) Apply *wh*-question formation to (a), targeting the direct object of the embedded clause, and compare the relative order of the embedded subject and verb in (b) and (c). (cf. Watanabe 1996: (39))

a. Elle a dit que Paul avait vu quelqu'un.
she has said that Paul had seen someone
'She said that Paul had seen someone.'

b. Qui a-t-elle dit que Paul avait vu ?
who has-she said that Paul had seen
'Who did she say Paul had seen?'

c. Qui a-t-elle dit qu'avait vu Paul ?
who has-she said that.had seen Paul
'Who did she say Paul had seen?'